Ayurveda translates into “The Science of Life,” and it relates predominantly to food and medicine. Ayurveda aims to explain and help treat human ailments using food, meditation, and other regimes by balancing the humors of the body: earth, air, fire, water, and ether. Each type of food that potentially makes up one’s diet, from the humble lentil to a leg of lamb, is documented carefully in terms of its health benefits and possible negative influences. Ayurveda, as a subsect of the major Hindu Vedas, is still very much in practice today.

The Agraharas that taught such knowledge were built on pieces of land bequeathed to keepers of the Hindu faith—known as Brahmans—who in return would maintain temples and religious sites on the land. These sites were often used as pilgrimage locations for people seeking higher spiritual knowledge from the Vedas. The costs of upkeep on the Agraharas were incurred by the royal Gupta family.

In addition to religious and spiritual learning, universities like the one at Taxila offered lessons in astronomy, mathematics, science, accounting, politics, law, arts, and architecture. It was a period of beautiful, intricate stone carvings, rock-etched architecture, and lifelike sculptures that makes up India’s Classical period artworks. Realistic renderings of the Vishnu, Shiva, and Buddha were crafted in paint, which can be found in the Ajanta Caves, as well as in stone, like the massive three-headed god at the Elephanta Caves. Rock-cut caves, dwellings, and public buildings are more plentiful in India than in any other part of the world, thanks to the incredible work of the pioneering builders of the Maurya Empire and then the determined perfectionists of Gupta-era architects

To create a rock-cut structure, the stone mason had to select an appropriately sized outcropping of solid rock, usually sandstone or in some cases marble. Masons also used the basalt hills of the Sahyadri mountain range in the western part of the country. It is believed that the first rock-cut caves carved out by early Indian builders were meant to mimic the darkness, isolation, and solitude of natural caves since the latter were revered by religious sects who used them to pray. By the Gupta era, cave building had been perfected and expanded to include massive rock-cut temples. These are a stunning sight to behold, rich in ornamental detail and large enough in scale to rival any free-standing structure of the age. From the humblest of caves—complete with carved, peaked archways and polished flat walls—to the highly intricate Mahabodhi Temple in Bodh